

INTERVIEW

LIGHTS, CAMERA ACTION!

***Varun Grover** makes his directorial debut with* **All India Rank**, *about a 17-year-old kid trying to crack the IIT entrance in Kota*

Q. The IIT film has become a mini genre in itself. What do you hope to add to the narrative with *All India Rank*?

I wanted to do three things. First, see it as a coming-of-age of a family and not just of the kid. Second, place the origin of the IIT hysteria that middle-class India had in the late 1990s. Third, keep it centred on the kid and not the coaching industry.

Q. What makes the 1990s so striking for you?

The gentleness of that era is something I see missing in today's youth. They are too aware, connected and sorted. At that time, we didn't know anything beyond our *mohallas*. I set it in 1997-98 because It was the 50th year of Independence, a great transition phase and the coming-of-age of a post-pubescent nation.

Q. You are a lyricist, screenwriter, stand-up comedian, author and, now, director. How do you juggle so many hats and which comes most naturally to you?

Stand-up comedy comes most naturally as it gives me the most joy. There's an immediate response and I get to speak—though it is getting more difficult—freely. Writing is like a second skin. The most difficult has been direction.

Q. Your stand-up special, 'Nothing Makes Sense', heads for a Europe-UK tour in April. What's the response to your blend of socio-political humour?

It is a mixed bag, because Indians outside are a bit more touchy about things in India. I understand it's a survival mechanism to be proud of the place they come from. But there are many Indians who understand how things are and want to listen to stories in a satirical, funny show. ■

–Suhani Singh

